

May, 2024

It is the month  
the thirteen-year and seventeen-year cycles synchronize.  
Cicada broods XIII and XIX  
co-emerge  
from the ground  
for the first time in  
221 years.  
Seven states  
across the Midwest and Southeast  
will reverberate with cicada song  
until mid-June,  
when the mothers lay their eggs  
on the ends  
of tree branches.  
The newly minted nymphs hatch  
one month later.  
They chew through the branches,  
free-fall to the roots,  
feast on sap,  
then follow  
their ancestral path  
down  
deep  
into  
the earth:  
to burrow,  
incubate,  
wait.

Jupiter enters Gemini  
for the first time in twelve years.  
Rafah is on fire.  
I rage,  
make calls,

watch the videos to the end  
until my cheeks burn,  
knowing it is both  
the most  
and the least  
I can do.

She gets her first loose tooth.

He gets his first pimple.

It is the month  
I see my mother  
look genuinely happy  
in a photo  
for the first time.

When the largest solar storm  
since 2003  
erupts above us.  
We wake the kids at midnight,  
run down to the riverbank—  
pajamas and bare feet—  
to gawk at the aurora.  
They are hard to see  
with the naked eye,  
but strangely brilliant  
through my iPhone's lens:  
pink, green, gold.

We visit the Field Museum in Chicago.  
We sit on a bench in front of Sue,  
the world's largest  
fully intact T-rex fossil.

She dominates an entire wing  
of the top floor.  
We stare silently for  
thirty minutes,  
then hold up photos  
of chicken skeletons,  
then human skeletons,  
comparing them to Sue's.  
None are wildly different  
from the other.  
We wonder if apex predators  
get a bad rap.

In a quiet corner  
of the museum's basement  
we see a mummy  
with our own eyes.  
She is smaller than I anticipated,  
not much bigger than a large child.  
I fall in love  
with the wide gold wings  
gilding her chest,  
glinting in the late afternoon light.  
I wonder  
how her afterlife is going.  
And whether it is disgust or fascination  
rippling through my belly  
when I see her  
partially exposed  
Maxilla.

On a sunny Tuesday  
at the Shedd Aquarium  
I pet a stingray  
with my bare hands.  
Its skin is impossibly smooth.  
Tears spring unexpectedly  
when I see

the white beluga whales  
somersault  
through the blue water.  
And again  
when I realize:  
my boy is crying too.

We gather  
three generations of relatives  
for a family reunion  
in rural Illinois.  
Forty of us emerge  
from both coasts.  
We swarm the platform  
at my uncle's tiny church.  
We sing How Great Thou Art  
for the local congregation  
of twenty-three souls.  
We learn our great-great-grandmother  
used to sneak cigarettes and magazines.  
I get called a cheater during trivia.  
We debate parenting philosophies  
with the cousins.  
Then we fly home.

It is the month  
I start taking voice lessons again.

The month I sit in the clinic  
every week,  
IV in my left arm,  
as iron is pumped back  
into my watery blood.

It is the month  
I remember I love sex.

The month I bleed with the full moon.  
I hear that makes me a red witch.

It is not  
the month we finish construction  
on our house.  
But it is the month  
my brother—  
intrepid archaeologist—  
hauls away  
2,500 pounds  
of trash and debris,  
unearthing, presenting:  
the yard.  
The yard where my mother  
plants flowers.  
Where my sister hangs  
window boxes.  
Where we gather on Mother's Day  
with old and new loves.

And my Beloveds?  
She moves back to the Rockies  
and prepares to give birth again—  
this time at forty-five—  
weeks after her eldest  
returns home from college.  
The cycle begins again.

My Love up north  
marks both her parents' passings:  
mother ten years ago,  
father this time last year.  
She schedules the surgery.  
She makes herself a promise.

My Dear One  
hears a story stir  
deep underground—  
a story buried with him  
after the car accident in 2000.  
She sings it  
back to the surface  
with the cicadas.  
Sings it with her whole chest  
for the people,  
to the cameras.  
Then sings him  
back to sleep  
so he can finally rest.

He and I  
see a prick of light  
pierce our familiar dark.  
We realize  
maybe we have been  
in a tunnel all along—  
dark inside  
what is, in fact,  
a swelling cocoon,  
not a tomb,  
not the bottom of a well  
as we feared.  
We begin to imagine  
in earnest  
what it would be  
to emerge  
from survival  
into something  
more sustainable,  
more vibrant—  
something we recognize,  
something we love.

It is the month  
I uncover ancient runes  
embedded in my body:  
fossils,  
relics,  
imprints  
of abuser and abused  
I must exhume  
and alchemize.  
And I do—  
into gold  
shimmering in my veins  
like the Nile or Thames  
when the light hits just right.

May is the month  
my nine-year-old—  
blood of my blood—  
takes my hand  
unprompted  
as we walk through the park.  
The month  
my five-year-old—  
bone of my bone—  
falls asleep on my chest,  
her head heavy  
on my sternum,  
feet reaching  
all the way  
to the center  
of my tibias.  
(How?)

It is the month  
I realize  
human ashes,  
viewed under a microscope,

are indistinguishable  
from nebulae  
seen through a telescope.

The month  
the nymph surrenders.  
The mother emerges.  
The month  
I finally wade  
out  
into  
the river,  
offering my exhausted attempts  
at control—  
my pretense,  
my projections,  
denials,  
fantasies,  
and waning light—  
to her swift current.  
At least for today.

It is the month  
hope returns.  
The month  
I wonder  
if I can write a poem.

*By Abby Buchanan (2024)*